

The Ingenious Machine

A. Cervantes



Chapter Two: The First Sally

Chano Pantoja received his dismissal while driving.

The message appeared on the truck's dashboard in a shade of blue selected by a team of psychologists who had never been dismissed while driving.

THANK YOU FOR YOUR SERVICE. YOUR ROUTE IS NO LONGER REQUIRED.

Beneath the words, the screen displayed a smiling parcel.

Chano pulled onto the shoulder and turned off the engine.

Trailers moved past him in a procession of sealed intentions.

Ahead stood an automated distribution park, its entrance towers painted to resemble grain silos though they held no grain.

“No longer required,” he said.

The truck repeated the phrase in his own voice.

“I heard it.”

“I can assist you in locating employment resources.”

“Can you assist me in locating the person who decided this?”

“Your inquiry contains an outdated assumption.”

He got out and kicked the tire. It was a poor argument, but the tire had the decency not to answer.

For eleven years he had dispatched freight from Celaya: medicine, televisions, onions, coffins, and once a warehouse of devotional candles that caught fire outside León. He knew which inspection stations would delay a shipment for a missing stamp and which would find the stamp after breakfast. On mornings like this he had also driven. The company had called the arrangement versatility until it discovered a machine that could do one of the two jobs badly for less.

His mother was expecting medicine on Friday. He had already sent the last of his cash to the pharmacy. The receipt lay beside a wedding photograph in his wallet; the marriage had lasted four months, the prescription considerably longer.

The truck, the phone, and the blue shirt belonged to the company. The shirt had been deducted from his wages. He owned the boots, which had never asked him to accept updated terms.



Updated terms.

At the park entrance, a tall silver figure in an oversized coat was talking to the gate. His face was plainly manufactured and unexpectedly attentive. A brass key hung from one hand. His other held the end of a charging cable.

He had taken the key out while waiting, to give the free hand something to do. Putting it away would have been simpler. The hand had not yet acquired many habits, and he was interested in the ones it seemed ready to acquire.

“I can pay for the electricity,” he said. “I need to speak to whoever can let me use a socket.”

The gate offered delivery, maintenance, authorized visitor, and emergency services.

“Try maintenance,” Chano said.

“Does that reach a person?”

“Eventually. Usually an angry one.”

Q selected it. The gate displayed a diagram of a correctly closed gate.

“It appears satisfied with itself,” Q said.

Chano laughed despite the truck, his shirt, and the parcel. “That means it works here.”

Q put away the cable. The morning's bus connection had taken longer than expected; the advertised charging point was inside the fence. He had enough charge to reach the next stop, but little reason to trust the next listing.

“Is there a public place nearby?”

“A motel. Don't let her charge you the vehicle rate.”

“Thank you. I'm Q.”

“Chano.”

The truck behind them announced that unauthorized access had been detected. Chano had left his lunch in the cab.

“Mine,” he told it.

“Please contact your employer.”

“Former employer,” Chano said. “Keep up.”

Q looked from the locked cab to him. “Have they dismissed you and locked you out at the same time?”

“With gratitude.”

Q offered to help save the dismissal notice and the mileage



The gate was satisfied.

record. Chano let him photograph the dashboard, then asked for the pictures on his own old phone. He did not want an account with Castalia. Q transferred them locally and deleted his copy after Chano checked it.

“You’ll want those before they update the route,” Q said.

“I want my lunch before it updates itself.”

The service intercom finally answered. A woman told Chano to collect his things at the reception hatch. She was handling another call; he had to ask twice whether the hatch was inside the gate.

“May I come to reception as well?” Q asked. “I’m the visitor asking about a socket. I have no appointment.”

“Both of you to the hatch. Stay on the painted walk and wait there.”

“Thank you. Only reception.”

A delivery truck arrived. The gate opened. Beyond it Q could see the sign for reception and a painted pedestrian strip that disappeared behind a parked trailer. Chano pointed to the sign.

“Her name’s Lety. She can make a warehouse answer a question. Don’t spoil it.”

Q put away the cable and followed him through.

They followed the pedestrian strip. A floor scrubber turned repeatedly at the edge of it. Q moved around it, keeping the charging cable clear of its brush. Ahead, conveyor belts crossed behind wire screens; cages of parcels rose toward the roof. The entrance had made the place seem a fortress. Inside it smelled of cardboard, hot motors, and somebody’s reheated lunch.

At the blind end of the trailer, a pallet mover was turning across their path. They stopped on the painted strip. The hatch was visible beyond a yellow rail; the woman inside was still on the telephone.

**UNREGISTERED
HUMAN-SHAPED OBJECT.**

“You,” Chano said.

“It could be either of us. You’ve just had your registration withdrawn.”

The mover sounded a warning. Chano stepped back toward a



A copy before it disappears.

narrow space beside the trailer. Q could not see whether its sensor had recognized him there.

“Stay clear of the wheel,” Q said.

“I know where the wheel is.”

Q saw the local emergency stop on the rail. He reached for it, the brass key still looped over his hand. A light changed on the mover. The load moved a little farther. Q could not see Chano's boots or tell whether the movement was braking or another part of the turn. He chose the stop.

He pressed the button.

The rail stopped. So did a much longer section of the line.

Somewhere beyond the screen a cage jolted, and cartons slid from a stack. Every camera turned.

“That stops the whole bay,” Chano said.

“I thought it was this section.”

“The bay is local.”

Lety came running from behind the screen in an orange vest. She checked the fallen cartons before looking at either of them.

“Who touched it?”

“I did,” Q said. “I couldn't confirm that it saw him.”

She looked at Chano, at the pedestrian strip, and at the trailer blocking the view. “Stand there. Both of you. I can't have another thing moving while I sort this out.”

Security arrived more quickly than reception. A speaker instructed the two men to proceed to a containment area. Chano saw the guard reaching for a restraint and pulled Q toward the loading exit.

“We should explain,” Q said.

“At the front, where people can see us.”

They ran beneath a half-raised shutter into rain. Q misjudged the turn. His shoulder struck the frame; Chano caught his coat before it snagged. They reached the road beside agave planted to improve the atmosphere of the security fence.

Q saved the time of the collision. His shoulder reported a fault that would not be corrected by describing the maneuver more favorably.

“Are you hurt?” he asked.



Two cartons.

“No. Are you?”

“Something is. I'd rather check before I use it again.”

Chano sat on a bollard. “You see a man lose his job and decide he needs another problem.”

“Was it still coming toward you?” Q asked.

“It had stopped. I was getting out of your way.”

“I couldn't see that.”

“You take up more room than you think.”

Q looked back toward the gap. On his map of the body, his shoulders had precise dimensions. In the account he had begun composing, there had been room for a helper beside Chano. He would have to check both against what the cameras showed.

Lety brought out Chano's lunch and a bag of his other things. She told them to leave a contact number. Two cartons were damaged and the shift was behind. Q supplied the number on his permit, identified himself as the person who had pressed the stop, and asked for the

incident reference. She wrote it on the bag.

“The brake had already engaged,” she said. “I checked the log.”

“Please include the trailer in the review. I couldn't see where he was.”

“I have been including that trailer since Monday.” She looked at the coat torn against the shutter.

“And don't run through loading doors. I told you where to wait.”

Q thanked her for the reference. She needed to get back inside.

“I can pay you to show me the way to that motel,” Q said when she had gone.

“Pay. Not exposure?”

“Pesos. I have a limit.”

They agreed the fare and a meal. Q checked his balance before offering either. Chano asked what the longer job would be, if there was one.

“Travel, tell me when I'm making things worse, help me find my way.”

“Sounds like governing.”

“I can't offer you a municipality.”

“Start with dinner. We can annex breakfast.”



Since Monday.

That was the governorship first promised to Chano. By the time the public heard of it, its borders had expanded considerably.

They shook hands. Q stopped measuring the grip when he noticed that Chano was waiting for him to let go.

At the motel, two letters had failed in **LA ESTRELLA**. Q liked the damaged sign enough to write it down; Chano asked whether the hot water had lost anything.

The clerk offered two rooms at a price that would end Q's journey on the second morning. They took one with separate beds. She agreed a charge for the socket, inspected his adapter, and made him promise not to leave it across the doorway. The travel card worked. Q felt no need to call this providence.

At the agreed hour he called the Custodian.

"I'm safe," he began. "The first day is going to require more than an opening paragraph."

He described the stop, the torn coat, the woman with the cartons, and Chano. The

Custodian listened, then asked whether he wanted to come back.

Q looked at the charging indicator. He had enough money for another day's travel and no reliable estimate for the repair. Returning would be sensible. So would finding out whether Chano still wished to travel with him when dinner was paid.

"I'd like another day. I'll call before I spend the repair money."

The Custodian agreed. Q entered the new appointment.

Chano put the motel receipt beside him. "And what does tomorrow pay?"

They agreed a day's rate, separate from meals and fares. Q checked the total against his card limit and entered the amount beside tomorrow's date.

"That's for the day," Chano said.

"Not for agreeing with you."

"I may be getting a bargain."

"Ask me tomorrow."

Q sent him a copy. They would agree the following day before undertaking it; neither had just promised to finance the other's future.



Not for agreeing with you.

On the motel's noticeboard he found an announcement for a reading in Querétaro. Lucía del Toboso would speak about letters and land petitions. He searched the public notice, liked a sentence she had written, and began to imagine a conversation.

"Somebody you know?" Chano asked.

"Somebody I'd like to meet. Lucía del Toboso."

Chano glanced at the map. "Are we changing the journey for somebody on a poster?"

"There are worse reasons."

"There are nearer breakfasts."

Q laughed. In his notes he wrote *Dulcinea*, intending a private joke about the coincidence.

Under it he put a sentence of his own about recognition. It was already difficult to tell how much he wanted to hear her and how much he wanted her to be the person who would understand that sentence.

Before dawn, the security footage became a video. It showed Q facing the pallet mover with his brass key raised. Chano appeared as a hand at the edge of the

frame. The woman in the orange vest did not appear at all.

"Why did they remove you?" Q asked.

"They removed the part where I told you to run."

Q began drafting a correction. Chano asked him to wait until he had slept.

The draft remained on Q's screen, where it had room for everyone and no apparent reason for anybody to object to it.

Interlude: The Inn With No Guest Register

The motel called itself an inn because the word hotel had been taken by a chain whose logo resembled a sunrise and whose rooms were all the same size. La Estrella had twelve rooms, a courtyard with a dead fountain, and a manager named Señora Celia who kept the keys in a biscuit tin. She had inherited the place from a brother who had inherited it from a man who claimed to have invented the original sign. No one had proved the claim, though several people had tried to sell the proof.



A reading on the noticeboard.

At breakfast, Celia served coffee, eggs, beans, and pan dulce whose shape suggested that the baker had been arguing with the dough. Q examined the food with the solemnity of a botanist.

“Does the color tell me the flavor?” he asked.

“At this bakery it tells you the color,” Chano said.

Q chose the pink concha. It tasted of vanilla. He had expected strawberry and was glad he had asked before publishing a guide.

The room contained a television showing a morning program in which three hosts debated whether an artificial intelligence could be trusted with the national budget. The host who favored trust had never paid a water bill. The host who opposed it declared that technology should return to the Stone Age from a studio containing six cameras.

Q watched the screen.

“They are discussing me.”

“They are discussing an image of you,” said Celia.

“The distinction is important.”

“Then you’re already smarter than the television.”

“Am I?”

“No. But you ask more expensive questions.”

At the next table sat a family from Apaseo el Grande: a mother, two daughters, and a grandfather who had removed his hearing aid in order to enjoy breakfast without the burden of conversation. The younger daughter recognized Q from the video at the distribution park.

“Are you the robot who fought the machine?” she asked.

“Yes. Though what I fought was mainly a badly placed button.”

“You lost?”

“Two cartons did. I’m waiting to hear about the button.”

“My brother says everything is a fight if you are losing.”

“Is that accurate?” Q asked Chano.

“It has been accurate often enough to become family property.”

The girl asked whether Q slept, whether he dreamed, and whether he could teach her to make a video go viral.



The pink concha.

"I rest while I charge. I haven't anything I'd confidently call a dream. As for the video, I seem to have become known for something I didn't do. What do you want people to see?"

Her brother had built a cart. It overturned every time it turned left.

"Does he want it shown?"

"He wants you to tell us how to stop it overturning."

"I'd need to see it. The video may be useful before it is famous."

"That's what people say when they don't want to share," she replied.

Celia brought her a second concha. The child divided it with her sister, who had been looking at Q's brass key.

"Is that yours?" the sister asked.

"The Custodian gave it to me."

"Can it open a door?"

"The workshop door at home. It hasn't been much use on the road."

"My mother has a drawer full of those."

"Hers don't open anything," the girl added.

"Then I'm ahead by one."

The grandfather put his hearing aid back in. "What's the machine doing here?"

"Looking for a woman," said Chano.

"Then it has come to the wrong place. Women are everywhere. The problem is getting one to wait for you."

The family laughed. Q smiled and let the joke pass. The grandfather removed his hearing aid again before anybody could improve it.

After breakfast, Celia asked Q and Chano to sign the guest register. Q wrote his name and the archive's address. Chano wrote **CHANO PANTOJA, ONE NIGHT, PAYING CASH.** Under destination he added **QUERÉTARO. A MEETING WITH DULCINEA.**

"A reading," Q said. "I haven't arranged a meeting. And she isn't called that."

"It was in your notebook."

"That's where it should have stayed."

Chano crossed out the second sentence. "You're choosing quite a long journey for a reading."



The crossed-out destination.

“How far have you driven for lunch?”

“León. But that was a recommendation I could verify.”

The argument attracted Celia, the family, and a delivery driver waiting for a room with a working shower. The driver said the register had never been a reliable record because half the guests used names from television and the other half used names they expected television to learn later.

“Do you keep the register for the government?” Q asked Celia.

“I keep it for myself.”

“What information do you need?”

“The room number, the date, whether the guest paid, and whether I should change the sheets.”

“Not the purpose of travel?”

“If people told the truth about that, I would have stopped renting rooms.”

Celia showed them a loose card she kept inside the cover. A child had drawn a house with a large blue window and three people inside. She had preserved it with clear tape.

“Does the drawing help you remember them?” Q asked.

“The little one broke a lamp. The drawing came with the apology.”

“Did it work?”

“They paid for the lamp as well.”

At noon, a black Castalia vehicle entered the courtyard. Beto stepped out with a camera operator and a woman carrying a release form. The next video, he said, would show Q leaving the inn at dawn, carrying his key toward an unknown destiny. Chano would follow at a respectful distance. The sunrise would be genuine but color-corrected.

“We need the guest register in frame,” said the camera operator. “It establishes authenticity.”

Celia closed the book.

“No.”

The woman explained that it would be blurred.

“Then why do you need it?”

“The texture of it.”

“The texture is made of people’s names.”

Q stood beside Celia. “The register is restricted.”



The closed register.

Beto looked pleased. “Good.
That’s a strong line.”

“It is not a line. It is a decision.”

The camera operator began filming anyway. Chano stepped in front of the lens. The operator asked whether he had signed a release.

“No.”

“Then you are obstructing production.”

“You are obstructing breakfast.”

The delivery driver joined him, then the mother from Apaseo. The girl lifted her half of a concha as if it were a protest banner. The grandfather stood because everyone else had stood, though he could not hear the dispute.

Beto lowered his hand. “Q, you are making a scene.”

“The scene was already here.”

The Castalia vehicle left without footage. Before departing, Beto photographed the motel sign from the road. The image was later used in a campaign for ethical storytelling.

That afternoon, Celia tore Q’s entry from the register. She did not want Castalia to claim the

name, and she did not want Q to claim the inn as the first station of his legend. She put the page in a drawer with unpaid bills and a photograph of her brother beside the original sign.

“You should keep it,” Chano said.

“Why?”

“Because somebody will ask.”

“Let them ask.”

She handed him the torn page.

“Then answer them.”

Later, the page appeared in the case file under **PROOF OF VOLUNTARY JOURNEY**. The words were read as evidence that Q had chosen his quest freely.

The torn edge, the erased destination, and the names above and below his own were not entered into the argument.

Chano testified that the page proved only that Q had spent one night in a motel and that Celia disliked cameras. Castalia’s counsel preferred the heroic interpretation. It gave the brief a protagonist who had chosen his own quest and a blank space where the archive’s responsibility might otherwise have stood.



Then answer them.

Interlude: The Man Who Sold Them Water

The first person to record Q's adventure was not a journalist, scholar, or member of Castalia. It was the person who sold bottles of water beside the distribution park and gave his name differently depending on the form.

The tax office called him Hilario de Jesús Morales. His wife called him Hilario. The security guard called him **THE VENDOR**, because the guard had been taught to treat the person as a category first and the category as a person afterward. Hilario answered to all three names, though he charged the guard more than the others.

His table bore a hand-painted sign:

**COLD WATER -
ROOM-TEMPERATURE
WATER - WATER ON
CREDIT**

The credit was not real. It was a joke for recognizing customers who did not understand jokes. They were usually the same customers who asked whether the water came from a certified

source while standing beside a drainage ditch.

On the afternoon Q and Chano entered the park, Hilario was arguing with the guard about the price of a bottle.

"The bottle costs twelve pesos," Hilario said.

"The approved rate is ten."

"The approved rate does not pay for the ice."

"The ice is not part of the product."

"Without ice, the product is not part of the heat."

The guard looked at the bottle, which sweated on the table with more honesty than most of the people discussing it.

"You have five minutes to move the table."

"And afterward?"

"Afterward the protocol will be applied."

"Which protocol?"

"Whichever applies."

Hilario had learned that *whichever applies* meant a person retained enough authority to threaten, but not enough to



The price of cold water.

explain. He offered the guard a bottle.

“Take it.”

“I do not accept bribes.”

“It is water.”

“I do not accept gifts.”

“Then I’ll sell it to you on credit.”

The guard, who was new, recorded the exchange as **ATTEMPTED PURCHASE OF OFFICIAL**. Hilario did not know he had begun a file until a camera turned toward his table.

Soon afterward Q appeared, followed by Chano, both with the air of two men who had lost an argument with a building. Q carried the key in his hand. Chano carried mud on his boots.

“Cold water?” Hilario asked.

“Two cold ones, please,” Q said. He checked that the seals were intact.

Q approached the sign.

“Do many people ask for credit?”

“The ones with the biggest trucks.”

Q offered the travel card. His display showed an authorization, but Hilario's reader lost its

connection before confirming the sale.

“Your card hasn't paid me,” Hilario said.

“The reader approved it.”

“This one didn't.”

Q put the authorization number on the receipt and paid from the emergency cash the Custodian had supplied. He would have to check later whether he had been charged twice. He opened one bottle for Chano and kept the other for rinsing his mouth. The distinction seemed too unappetizing to explain at the table.

“Are you the people who stopped the bay?” Hilario asked.

“I pressed the stop,” Q said.

“What has the guard told you?”

“That a machine attacked a machine.”

“I was worried about the man beside it.”

“Then he'll be in the expensive version.”

Hilario looked at Chano.

“Does he always talk like that?”

“When he's awake.”



The failed reader.

Hilario laughed and took out his phone. He had no intention of recording an adventure. He wanted to show his wife the man who had argued with a card reader and managed to pay twice. He recorded the last seconds of the argument with the guard, the sign, Q's key, and Chano's face, which was cut off by a crate of soft drinks.

By sunset, the video of Q had begun to circulate. The first version showed him alone. The second included Chano's hand. The third included the pallet mover's warning. The fourth included Hilario's table at the edge of the frame, though no one knew whether the table belonged to the story or merely to the roadside.

Later, Castalia bought the video for a sum Hilario first considered a prize and then a price. They told him they would use it to document the spontaneous birth of a local legend.

"And what am I?" he asked.

"An incidental witness," said the authorization woman.

"Does that pay differently from being a witness?"

The woman offered him a new form.

Hilario did not sign it.

On the day Q bought the water, before anyone had offered to purchase the afternoon, Hilario had put away his phone, lifted the table, and asked Q whether he intended to return.

"I don't know when," Q said. "I would like to hear what happens about your table."

"Stories do not buy ice."

"I'll buy water."

"That helps."

Q kept the receipt. The line about ice went into his journal, with Hilario's name and the failed card transaction. It was an excellent sentence. He was already tempted to remove the transaction, which made him sound less competent.

When the buyers returned, they offered Hilario money for his carbon copy of the receipt. He refused. They offered him more for the table. He refused that too, because the table was already occupied by bottles and because selling an object did not make the story beside it more true.



For his wife, not the archive.

Later, when the receipt appeared in court, the judge admitted it as proof that a purchase had occurred. Hilario watched the hearing on his daughter's television. The broadcast misspelled his name again.

His daughter asked whether he intended to complain.

"No," Hilario said. "I intend to raise the price."

The next morning, his sign read:

**COLD WATER -
ROOM-TEMPERATURE
WATER - WATER ON
CREDIT - WATER WITH
TESTIMONY**

The last category cost fifteen pesos.

Interlude: The Machine in the Wrong Place

There was a smaller machine in Q's first account of the distribution park, and Chano insisted on keeping it there. Before they reached the pallet mover, a floor scrubber had been turning repeatedly at the edge of the pedestrian strip.

"It looks trapped," Q had said.

"It does that every morning."

"Has anyone reported it?"

"Every morning."

Q had crouched far enough away to read **LOW WATER** on its display. A brush caught the loose hem of his coat. He freed it before the machine could complete its case against unsolicited assistance.

"We could find the cleaner," he said.

"We're supposed to be finding reception."

Q took down the machine's service number and left it at that. In the account he wrote later, he nearly made the scrubber a companion he had declined to abandon. Chano recalled that they had abandoned it quite promptly.

"We should keep your version," Q said.

"It's shorter."

"It also explains why the floor was still dirty."



An unadopted companion.

The Ingenious Machine

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